Problem Solving Styles

In general, people try to solve their problems in one of four ways. These are known as problem solving styles. You will probably use a variety of styles, but it is still a good idea to know which style you prefer. To understand what kind of problem solver you are, complete the following questionnaire.

Rank the words or phrases that are listed under each statement.

1-Amost Always 2-Sometimes 3-Seldom 4-Never

1. Things I consider in solving a problem: 1a) _____ views of other people 1b) _____ views of experts 1c) _____ relevant information 1d) _____ personal experience	**2. How I usually approach a problem:** 2a) _____ talk to people 2b) _____ explore the background 2c) _____ collect facts 2d) _____ try out a solution
3. The way I like to interact with people: 3a) _____ try to convince them 3b) _____ inform them 3c) _____ interview them 3d) _____ challenge them	**4. I like problem solving best when I:** 4a) _____ weigh alternatives 4b) _____ gather complete data 4c) _____ explore the cause 4d) _____ take decisive action
5. The statement that best expresses my view of problem solving is: 5a) _____ to be successful a solution must be acceptable to everyone involved 5b) _____ we have a lot to learn from our past experiences 5c) _____ solving most problems comes down to figuring out the cause- and –effect relationships 5d) _____ in the real world, you often have to solve a problem without a complete understanding of what has caused it	

To see what your style is, write the scores from the questions above next to the corresponding letters in the following section. Your lowest score on the survey indicates your preferred style.

1a) _____	1b) _____	1c) _____	1d) _____
2a) _____	2b) _____	2c) _____	2d) _____
3a) _____	3b) _____	3c) _____	3d) _____
4a) _____	4b) _____	4c) _____	4d) _____
5a) _____	5b) _____	5c) _____	5d) _____
Total: _____ (**D**)	Total: _____ (**P**)	Total: _____ (**De**)	Total: _____ (**C**)

SCORES:

(D) Diplomat _____ my score

Interested in reaching consensus (when people all agree)
Learns best from talking to those involved
Often values opinions more than facts
Focuses on practical solutions
Can be very persuasive
Needs to guard against missing timelines as a result of taking too much time gathering opinions

(P) Professor _____ my score

Interested in theories
Seeks lot of background information
Learns from relationships to other situations
Values detachment from issues (tries to be very objective)
Relates to others by giving and getting information
Needs to guard against indecision and impracticality (always waiting for more information)

(De) Detective _____ my score

Interested in finding the cause of the problem
Focuses on relevant facts
Prefers to make direct observations of situations
Tends to follow a consistent method or process
Tries to establish clear cause-and-affect relationships
Needs to guard against inflexibility and insensitivity to people

(C) Champion _____ my score

Interested in results
Finds a solution by trying one out
Wants to achieve success without help from others
Trusts his or her instincts
Good in crisis situations when there is no time for analysis
Needs to guard against impulsiveness and uncooperativeness